

“Whatever happens, we have got The Maxim gun, and they have not.”

HILAIRE BELLOC, IN HIS POEM, “THE MODERN TRAVELLER” (1898)

firing, Maxim fitted a jacket containing water around the gun's barrel to keep it cool. His creation was aided by the invention of smokeless powder (see pp.142–43). This new propellant produced less residue to clog a barrel, and developed its explosive pressure more gradually, thereby imparting less shock to the mechanism. Maxim had observed that the guns, operated by a crank handle or a lever, were hard to train onto moving targets. With his new gun, all the user had to do was aim and shoot—the gun would continue to fire until its ammunition supply was exhausted. Maxim's genius had conceived a new way to use explosion energy for operating a gun and created a true machine-gun.

On the battlefield, the Maxim gun brought shocking carnage and prompted a change in military tactics. It was an ideal weapon for defending a position, whether a building or a trench, and Maxim-equipped armies began to lure enemies into “charging,” at which point

they could be mown down. This was seen for the first time when British colonial forces used the Maxim in the Matabele War (1893–94) in modern-day Zimbabwe. In a nation where firearms were not in common use by non-Europeans, its impact was as much psychological as physical. In one battle, it is said that 50 British soldiers with just four Maxim guns fought off 5,000 Ndebele warriors. Pitched battles and charging began to become obsolete. This weapon was again used to devastating effect in Sudan in the Battle of Omdurman (1898), fought between the British and Arab Mahdist forces. Used successfully against the charging tactics of the Arabs, the Maxim enabled the British forces to kill more than 10,000 of the enemy while losing only about 50 soldiers.

Maxim's patent became a blueprint for many modern self-loading firearms that followed and have become icons of their type, bringing with them a new level of horror to armed conflict.

▼ THE MAXIM IN CHITRAL

By the 1890s, the British Army decided to issue the Maxim gun to every battalion. Captain Alan L. Peebles of the Devonshire Regiment had seen the Maxim in action in Waziristan in 1894. In 1895, he brought a pair of Maxim guns to Chitral (in modern-day Pakistan) as part of a British expeditionary force sent to recapture a fort overtaken by Afghan tribesmen. Pictured here are some soldiers from the force with a Maxim Gun.



KEY FIGURE

HIRAM STEVENS MAXIM
(1840–1916)

American-born Hiram Maxim emigrated to Britain in 1881 and became a British subject in 1900. His childhood experience of being knocked over by a rifle's recoil may have been instrumental in leading him to harness a gun's recoil energy, eventually designing the Maxim machine-gun. His inventions included, among others, his “Captive Flying Machine”—a very successful fairground ride, which helped fund his experiments. He was knighted in 1901.



AFTER >>

Maxim's gun turned the old, manual machine-guns into obsolete technology. Once it got into production and its capabilities became known, it provided the cutting edge every military power wanted in order to give themselves supremacy over a supposed enemy.

• **LIGHT MACHINE-GUNS** developed rapidly, leading to guns such as the Browning Automatic Rifle (see p.194). These could be carried by one man with a supply of ammunition and fired from the hip while moving.



BROWNING
AUTOMATIC RIFLE

• **SUBMACHINE-GUNS** were lighter, more compact, and fired pistol ammunition. The most iconic gun of this period was the Thompson submachine-gun (see pp.212–13).



THOMPSON
SUBMACHINE-GUN

• **MODERN FULLY AUTOMATIC** and semiautomatic weapons are the offspring of these early developments, relying on the same basic recoil-operation principles for their action. The technology extended beyond heavy weaponry to handguns and spurred the development of self-loading, semiautomatic pistols using recoil energy.